The Wedding Survival Quick-Start Checklist

12 Pages. Zero Fluff. Everything You Actually Need to Know First.

A free gift from WeddingForge | 2026 Edition

[Image: warm flat-lay of a planner notebook, cup of coffee, ring, and pen on a linen surface]

Welcome, Future Survivor

Here is what nobody tells you when you get engaged: the average American couple spends **$35,400** on their wedding in 2026. About 43% of them go over budget. Nearly 1 in 3 reports serious vendor problems. And most of the stress? Entirely preventable.

This checklist is the antidote to all of that.

I have worked through 200+ weddings — as a coordinator, a planner, a maid of honor, and once, memorably, as the person who had to tell a bride her florist had gone out of business three days before her ceremony. I have seen what goes wrong. More importantly, I have seen what works.

This free 12-page guide gives you the frameworks, checklists, and scripts that actually move the needle. No Pinterest mood boards. No "just trust your heart" advice. Just the real playbook.

What's inside:

- [ ] First 48 Hours after engagement — what to do before you post to Instagram
- [ ] Month 1 Priority List — the 11 decisions that affect everything else
- [ ] The Budget Reality Check — honest 2026 numbers by category
- [ ] Venue Red Flags — what to look for before you sign anything
- [ ] Vendor Hiring Checklist — questions most couples never think to ask

- [ ] Guest List Drama Guide — how to handle every difficult conversation
- [ ] 6-Month Countdown — the tasks that sneak up on you
- [ ] 3-Month Final Push — the stuff nobody remembers until it's too late
- [ ] Week-of Survival Plan — delegate or die
- [ ] Day-of Emergency Kit — 37 items that will save you at least twice
- [ ] Scripts for every hard conversation (family, vendors, wedding party)

How to use this checklist:

Work through it in order if you're newly engaged. If your wedding is in 6 months or less, flip to the 6-Month Countdown on page 9 first, then circle back. Every checklist is designed to be actionable the same day you read it.

At the bottom of each page you'll find a **"If you do nothing else today" box** — the single most important action on that page.

Ready? Let's survive this.

The full 100-page Wedding Planning & Execution Survival Guide 2026 is available at [weddingforge.com] for $57 — and contains every template, script, and tracking sheet referenced in this guide.

Page 2: The First 48 Hours Checklist

Before You Post, Do These 11 Things

[Image: close-up of a hand holding a phone showing Instagram notifications, slightly out of focus, with an engagement ring in the foreground]

You just got engaged. Congratulations. Now put the phone down for exactly 30 minutes. Because the decisions you make in the next 48 hours will set the tone for the next 12–18 months of your planning life.

The First 48 Hours Checklist

STEP 1: SET A BOUNDARY AROUND THE NEWS (TONIGHT)

- [ ] Agree with your partner on who gets told first — in what order and by what method
- [ ] Decide: parents in-person, or by phone? (In-person is almost always worth the logistics)
- [ ] Set a "no posting" window (recommend: 24–48 hours so family hears it from you directly)
- [ ] Text any close family members who might see Instagram before you call them

STEP 2: CAPTURE THE INITIAL ENERGY (WITHIN 24 HOURS)

- [ ] Write down 3–5 words that describe the vibe/feeling you want your wedding to have
- [ ] Have your partner do the same independently
- [ ] Compare and circle the overlaps — that is your actual direction
- [ ] Take 10 minutes to write down your first instinct about guest count (you'll revisit this, but capture it now)

STEP 3: GET AHEAD OF THE BUDGET CONVERSATION (BEFORE YOU AGREE TO ANYTHING)

- [ ] Have a private money conversation with your partner: what is the number that would make you truly comfortable?
- [ ] Find out if either set of parents intends to contribute — and if so, how much, and with what expectations attached

- [ ] Do NOT agree to any vendor meetings, venue tours, or dress appointments until you have a rough budget range

STEP 4: CREATE A SHARED PLANNING HOME

- [ ] Set up one shared email address (e.g., smithwedding2026@gmail.com) for all vendor correspondence
- [ ] Create one shared folder (Google Drive or iCloud) for contracts, receipts, and inspiration
- [ ] Decide who is the primary point of contact for vendors — one name prevents miscommunication

STEP 5: DO THE DATE MATH

- [ ] Count months to your ideal wedding date
- [ ] If under 12 months: you are in fast-track mode — prioritize venue immediately
- [ ] If 12–18 months: standard planning timeline applies
- [ ] If over 18 months: use the extra time for budget building, not vendor obsessing

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> **If you do nothing else today:** Have the budget conversation with your partner before any vendor meeting happens. The number one source of wedding stress is misaligned financial expectations. Set the ceiling before you fall in love with anything.

Page 3: Month 1 Priority Checklist

The 11 Decisions That Affect Everything Else

[Image: a simple priority matrix drawn on paper — high urgency / high importance quadrant circled]

Most couples spend Month 1 on Instagram and Pinterest. The couples who stay sane — and on budget — spend Month 1 on decisions. Specifically, these 11. Every one of them constrains or enables all the decisions that come after.

Why order matters: Venue locks your date. Your date determines vendor availability. Guest count determines venue size. Venue size affects catering cost per head. Catering cost is typically 30–35% of your total budget. See how fast it cascades?

Do these in order.

THE MONTH 1 DECISION CHECKLIST

- [ ] **1. Establish your real budget** — not aspirational, real. Include a 10–15% contingency buffer.
- [ ] **2. Set your non-negotiable priorities** — what are the 2–3 things you will NOT compromise on? (Photography? Food quality? Open bar? Location?)
- [ ] **3. Determine the guest list ceiling** — a rough number, not a final list. 50, 100, 150, 200+? This single number controls your venue options and catering budget more than anything else.
- [ ] **4. Choose your general date range** — season, month, day of week. Saturday costs more. Sundays and Fridays are 15–25% cheaper. Off-season (Jan–March, Nov) can save 10–20%.
- [ ] **5. Decide your geography** — local, destination, or hybrid? Destination adds 20–30% for guests' costs and reduces attendance.
- [ ] **6. Identify your 2–3 venue must-haves** — outdoor ceremony? Historic aesthetic? On-site catering only? Minimum guest requirement?
- [ ] **7. Begin your vendor research list** — do not book yet, just compile names. Categories: photographer, caterer/venue, officiant, florist, DJ/band, hair & makeup.
- [ ] **8. Determine engagement photo priority** — if you want holiday card photos, they need to happen within 60–90 days of engagement. Book photographer now if that's your plan.

- [ ] **9. Consider engagement party** — who is hosting? Do you want one? Will it be regional or just local family? Setting expectations early prevents hurt feelings.
- [ ] **10. Decide who is "in the circle"** — who has input on planning decisions? Establish this early and explicitly. "I love your ideas AND this is our call" is a sentence you should practice.
- [ ] **11. Pick your planning style** — DIY-heavy, full service planner, or coordinator-only? This determines your time budget for the next 12 months.

> **If you do nothing else this month:** Lock in your guest count ceiling and your venue search criteria. Every other decision can flex. These two set the floor on your budget.

Page 4: Budget Reality Check

What $35,400 Actually Buys in 2026

[Image: a clean budget breakdown pie chart — photography, venue, catering, florals, music, attire, other]

Here is the honest breakdown. Based on 2026 Wedding Report and The Knot national averages for a 117-guest wedding.

2026 NATIONAL AVERAGE WEDDING BUDGET BREAKDOWN

CATEGORY	AVERAGE SPEND	% OF TOTAL	RANGE
Venue (rental + catering)	$12,500	35%	$6,000–$22,000
Photography + Videography	$4,800	14%	$2,500–$8,000
Florals + Décor	$3,200	9%	$1,500–$6,000
Music (DJ or Band)	$2,400	7%	$1,200–$5,500
Attire (dress, suit, alterations)	$2,100	6%	$800–$5,000
Catering (if separate from venue)	$4,600	13%	$2,800–$8,000
Hair + Makeup	$900	3%	$400–$1,800
Officiant	$450	1%	$200–$800
Stationery + Paper	$650	2%	$300–$1,500
Transportation	$800	2%	$400–$1,800
Rehearsal Dinner	$1,800	5%	$800–$4,000
Favors + Gifts	$700	2%	$300–$1,500
Contingency Buffer (recommended)	$3,500	10%	—
TOTAL	**$38,400**	**~110%**	—

Notice that the "average" already adds up to more than $35,400. This is because the 10% buffer gets spent almost every time.

THE 3 BUDGET RULES THAT ACTUALLY WORK

Rule 1: The Non-Negotiable Top 3 Pick the 3 categories that matter most to you. Invest there. Cut everywhere else without guilt.

Rule 2: The Per-Head Reality Check Take your total budget. Divide by your guest count. That number — your cost-per-head — needs to be at least $200 for a basic open-bar dinner reception. $300–$350 is comfortable. Under $175 means you will be cutting corners that show.

Rule 3: The 10% Lock Put 10% of your budget in a "Do Not Touch" envelope from day one. Do not earmark it for anything. Wedding planning always has surprises. Always.

QUICK BUDGET CALCULATOR

- My total budget: $__
- Minus 10% contingency: $__
- Spendable budget: $__
- Divided by guest count: $__ per head

> **If you do nothing else today:** Run the per-head math. If the number is under $175, either raise your budget or lower your guest count. There is no other option that doesn't create stress.

Page 5: Venue Hunting Checklist

What to Look For Before You Sign Anything

[Image: a couple touring a venue space — barn with string lights — one partner taking notes on a phone]

The venue is the single largest decision you will make. It sets the aesthetic, constrains your vendor choices, locks your date, and controls 35% of your budget. Most couples tour venues emotionally. Tour them like a detective instead.

BEFORE YOU TOUR ANY VENUE

- [ ] Get your guest count ceiling confirmed — do not tour any venue that cannot accommodate it comfortably
- [ ] Know your date range flexibility (3–4 target weekends minimum gives you negotiating power)
- [ ] Confirm the venue's pricing model: per-head, flat rental, or packages?
- [ ] Ask whether they require in-house catering or allow outside vendors
- [ ] Check their minimum spend requirement

DURING THE TOUR — QUESTIONS TO ASK OUT LOUD

- [ ] "What is included in the rental fee?" (Tables, chairs, linens, AV, parking, setup/breakdown time?)
- [ ] "What time does the music need to stop?" (Many venues cap at 10pm or 11pm)
- [ ] "What is your rain plan?" (Critical for outdoor venues — get the specific backup in writing)
- [ ] "How many weddings do you host per day / per weekend?" (Back-to-back events mean rushed turnovers)
- [ ] "Is there a noise ordinance?" (Outdoor venues and rural properties often have hard cutoffs)
- [ ] "What are the vendor restrictions?" (Some venues only allow from their preferred vendor list)
- [ ] "Is there a dedicated on-site coordinator, and what does their role include?"
- [ ] "What is your cancellation/force majeure policy?" (Post-2020, this is non-negotiable to review)

AFTER THE TOUR — THE 5-POINT VENUE AUDIT

Rate each venue 1–5 on:

- [ ] **Logistics**: Parking, accessibility, getting vendors in and out
- [ ] **Aesthetics**: Does it match our vibe without requiring heavy décor investment?
- [ ] **Value**: Does the per-head cost make sense for what's included?
- [ ] **Flexibility**: Can we bring our own vendors, extend the hours, adjust the layout?
- [ ] **Gut feeling**: Did the coordinator treat us like people, or like a transaction?

VENUE RED FLAGS — WALK AWAY IF YOU SEE THESE

- [ ] Coordinator is evasive about the cancellation policy
- [ ] No written rain plan for outdoor spaces
- [ ] Venue does not allow you to do a final walkthrough with vendors before the wedding
- [ ] "Preferred vendor" list that comes with undisclosed kickbacks
- [ ] Coordinator cannot answer basic questions without checking with management
- [ ] No itemized list of what is included — everything is "part of the package"
- [ ] Reviews mention consistent day-of communication failures

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> **If you do nothing else today:** Before you tour a single venue, run the per-head math from Page 4. Venues will feel amazing in person — go in with a number and stick to it.

Page 6: Vendor Hiring Checklist

Questions Most Couples Never Think to Ask

[Image: a couple sitting across a table from a vendor, notebooks open, professional but warm setting]

Your vendors are your team. A bad photographer cannot be re-hired after the day. A no-show DJ cannot be un-experienced. These questions separate the professionals from the people who will cost you sleep.

FOR EVERY VENDOR — THE UNIVERSAL QUESTIONS

- [ ] "Are you the person who will be at my wedding, or will you send a second shooter / associate / assistant?"
- [ ] "How many events do you book on the same day as mine?"
- [ ] "What happens if you have a personal emergency on my wedding day? Walk me through your backup plan."
- [ ] "What format do you deliver your final work in, and by what date?"
- [ ] "What do you need from us to do your best work?"

FOR PHOTOGRAPHERS SPECIFICALLY

- [ ] Request to see a full gallery from a recent wedding — not just highlight shots
- [ ] "What is your shooting style — photojournalistic, traditional, editorial?"
- [ ] "How do you handle low-light situations like indoor receptions or late-day ceremonies?"
- [ ] "What is included in the package — hours, second shooter, prints, digital files, album?"
- [ ] "Do we get full resolution images with rights to print?"
- [ ] "What is your turnaround time for final delivery?" (Industry average: 6–12 weeks)

FOR CATERERS / FOOD & BEVERAGE

- [ ] Request a tasting before signing — never book without one
- [ ] "Is the quoted price per head all-inclusive (service, setup, breakdown, gratuity)?" (It usually isn't)

- [ ] "What is your policy for dietary restrictions?" (Get specific: vegan, celiac, nut allergy)
- [ ] "How do you handle late arrivals to cocktail hour affecting the dinner timeline?"
- [ ] "What is your liability if food safety issues arise?"

FOR DJS / BANDS

- [ ] Ask to see a live performance or a video from a recent event
- [ ] "Do you take requests from guests?" (And do you want them to?)
- [ ] "What is your setup time and what do you need from the venue?"
- [ ] "Can we provide a 'Do Not Play' list?" (You should — make one)
- [ ] "What happens if your equipment fails mid-reception?"

THE CONTRACT NON-NEGOTIABLES

Every vendor contract must include:

- [ ] Full names and contact details of both parties
- [ ] Specific date, time, and location
- [ ] Exact services being provided (not just "photography" — spell it out)
- [ ] Payment schedule and what triggers each payment
- [ ] Cancellation policy — both yours and theirs
- [ ] Force majeure / emergency backup clause
- [ ] What happens if vendor is late or fails to perform

> **If you do nothing else today:** For whichever vendor you're meeting with next, add "Who will actually be at my wedding?" to your questions. The answer will tell you everything.

Page 7: Guest List Drama Survival Guide

Scripts for Every Difficult Conversation

[Image: a handwritten "A List / B List" notepad sketch with names redacted, coffee ring on the page]

The guest list is where weddings go to die. Not the budget, not the vendors — the guest list. Specifically, the conversations around the guest list. Here is the playbook.

THE GUEST LIST FRAMEWORK

Rule: Your guest list should have three tiers created before any invitations are discussed.

TIER	WHO	ACTION
A-List	Would not feel right without them	Invited immediately
B-List	Would love to have, space/budget permitting	Invited when A-list RSVPs come in
Regrets-Only	Family/colleagues you must acknowledge	Invited knowing they cannot attend

- [ ] Build the A-List together — no debate allowed, just list
- [ ] Build the B-List — this is the controversial one; keep it private
- [ ] Set a hard number: "We cannot exceed X guests without going over budget"
- [ ] Agree on the rule: if one person from a friend group is invited, all must be

THE HARD CONVERSATIONS — SCRIPTS

"Can I bring my plus-one?"

> "We're keeping our wedding really intimate, so we're not able to offer plus-ones for guests who haven't been in a long-term relationship. We made this call across the board to be fair to everyone — I hope you understand."

"Why isn't [cousin/colleague/childhood friend] invited?"

> "We had to make some really hard choices with our venue capacity. We made a rule about [how we drew the line — e.g., only inviting people we've seen in the last two years] and applied it consistently. It wasn't about anyone personally."

Parents adding names to "their list"

> "We're so grateful for your help with the wedding. We want to be upfront: we have a firm capacity of [X] guests. We've allocated [Y] spots for your guests to invite. Those are yours to fill however you'd like — but we can't go above that number."

"Are kids invited?"

> "We're hosting an adults-only evening so that everyone — including the parents — can enjoy themselves without worrying about little ones. We've got [babysitter referral / kids' room / etc.] as an option if that's helpful."

GUEST COUNT MANAGEMENT CHECKLIST

- [ ] Set the ceiling before discussing with any family member
- [ ] Create the tier system before any invitations are discussed
- [ ] Communicate "the rule" to both sets of parents at the same time
- [ ] Keep the B-list confidential — it comes out in the wash if guests compare notes
- [ ] Track RSVPs in a spreadsheet from day one (Name | Side | RSVP | Meal | Dietary needs | Table)

> **If you do nothing else today:** Have the "here is our guest count ceiling" conversation with both sets of parents before any names are discussed. Front-loading the constraint prevents resentment later.

Page 8: The 6-Month Countdown Checklist

The Tasks That Sneak Up on You

[Image: a six-month calendar spread with key dates circled in red and sticky notes on key weeks]

Six months out feels like forever. It is not. Here is what needs to happen — and when — or you will be doing it all in month one of the final stretch.

6 MONTHS OUT — LOCKS AND CONFIRMATIONS

- [ ] Venue contract signed and deposit paid
- [ ] Photographer booked and contract signed
- [ ] Caterer / food & beverage confirmed (or venue catering locked)
- [ ] DJ or band booked
- [ ] Officiant secured and ceremony structure discussed
- [ ] Wedding party formally asked (bridesmaids, groomsmen, etc.)
- [ ] Dress/suit shopping started — alterations need 4–5 months minimum
- [ ] Hotel room blocks reserved for out-of-town guests (ask for 20–30 rooms minimum)
- [ ] Wedding website launched (The Knot, Zola, Joy, or custom)
- [ ] Save-the-dates sent — physical or digital, does not matter, do it

4 MONTHS OUT — BUILDING THE MACHINE

- [ ] Final guest list locked. No additions after this point.
- [ ] Invitations designed and ordered (allow 4 weeks for printing + addressing)
- [ ] Florist hired and floral vision document shared
- [ ] Hair and makeup artist booked for you + wedding party
- [ ] Wedding day timeline drafted (ceremony, cocktail hour, reception, key moments)
- [ ] Transportation arranged (getting to venue, end-of-night getaway)
- [ ] Rehearsal dinner venue/host confirmed

- [ ] Honeymoon booked (if applicable)
- [ ] Menu finalized with caterer

3 MONTHS OUT — THE FINAL STRETCH BEGINS

- [ ] Invitations mailed (send 8–10 weeks before the date to allow for RSVPs)
- [ ] RSVP deadline set for 3–4 weeks before wedding
- [ ] Final dress/suit fitting confirmed
- [ ] Wedding favors ordered or DIY project started
- [ ] Marriage license requirements researched (varies by state — some require waiting periods)
- [ ] Seating chart started (even just rough zones — head table vs. round tables vs. family clusters)
- [ ] Second vendor walkthrough scheduled for 4–6 weeks out

THE 6-MONTH VENDOR CHECK-IN TEMPLATE

Send this to every booked vendor at the 6-month mark:

> "Hi [Name], we're reaching out to confirm our wedding date of [DATE] at [VENUE]. Our current plan is [CEREMONY TIME] with [RECEPTION START]. We'll schedule a final walkthrough call around 6–8 weeks out. Is there anything you need from us right now? Thanks so much."

> **If you do nothing else today:** Check this list against your current timeline. If you are inside 6 months and haven't done the first section, prioritize venue and photographer above everything else — they book up first.

Page 9: The 3-Month Final Push

The Stuff Nobody Remembers Until It's Too Late

[Image: a detailed day-of timeline printed and taped to a wall, with sticky notes in different colors]

Three months out means the machine is built. Now you're optimizing it. Most of the stress in the final weeks comes from tasks that should have been done here.

3 MONTHS OUT — ADMINISTRATION SPRINT

- [ ] Apply for marriage license (check your state's requirements — some need 30–60 days lead time)
- [ ] Confirm honeymoon bookings (flights, hotels, car, travel insurance)
- [ ] Order wedding favors (4–6 weeks if custom)
- [ ] Finalize seating chart — work from the RSVP list
- [ ] Write or source your vows — do not leave this for the week before
- [ ] Purchase wedding party gifts
- [ ] Arrange for someone to manage day-of cash/tips envelope

6–8 WEEKS OUT — FINAL VENDOR CALLS

- [ ] Schedule final walkthrough with venue coordinator
- [ ] Send all vendors a unified day-of timeline document
- [ ] Confirm delivery times with florist
- [ ] Confirm setup and breakdown times with DJ/band
- [ ] Confirm photographer arrival time and must-have shot list
- [ ] Book hair and makeup trial appointment (run this on an important date so you wear the look)
- [ ] Give your venue coordinator a vendor contact sheet (every vendor, name, cell, role)

4 WEEKS OUT — NAME CHANGES AND LOGISTICS

- [ ] Confirm final guest count with caterer (most require 2–3 week notice for final headcount)
- [ ] Finalize seating chart and send to venue

- [ ] Confirm transportation arrival/departure times
- [ ] Pick up wedding dress (have someone else keep it — not your closet)
- [ ] Set up a "wedding week" out-of-office or reduced-notification mode on your phone

THE DAY-OF TIMELINE TEMPLATE

TIME	EVENT	WHO IS RESPONSIBLE
T-4 hours	Hair and makeup begins	MOH coordinates
T-3 hours	Photographer arrives	Bride/groom prep shots
T-2 hours	Florist delivers	Venue coordinator receives
T-1 hour	Wedding party in position	Best man / MOH
T-30 min	Guests begin seating	Ushers
Ceremony	Start time	Officiant leads
+1 hour	Cocktail hour	DJ / band begins
+2 hours	Reception begins	MC / DJ announces

> **If you do nothing else today:** Apply for your marriage license this week if you haven't. The paperwork side of getting married is the least romantic and the most legally critical. Don't let it surprise you.

Page 10: Week-of Survival Plan

Delegate or Die

[Image: a whiteboard with a "command center" layout — tasks, names, and arrows showing delegation paths]

The week of your wedding, your job is to be present — not to manage logistics. If you are still managing logistics during wedding week, something went wrong in planning. Here is how to prevent that.

THE WEEK-OF DELEGATION LIST

Every task this week must be assigned to someone else by name.

TASK	WHO OWNS IT
Vendor contact on day of	Coordinator OR designated MOH/best man
Welcoming out-of-town guests	Family member — NOT the couple
Transporting wedding items to venue	Specific named person with a vehicle
Managing the tip envelopes	Best man or trusted family member
Keeping the schedule on ceremony day	Coordinator or MOH
Wrangling wedding party for photos	Photographer's second shooter
Managing vendor payments/final checks	Pre-arranged — do not do day-of

THE COUPLE'S WEEK-OF RULE: NO VENDOR CALLS

After Monday of wedding week:

- [ ] No calls to vendors unless there is an emergency
- [ ] No changes to the catering order
- [ ] No seating chart revisions
- [ ] Everything that can be delegated has been delegated

- [ ] Your phone is on Do Not Disturb by Thursday

WEEK-OF SELF-CARE NON-NEGOTIABLES

- [ ] Sleep 7+ hours Wednesday and Thursday nights (Friday night is chaos — bank sleep early)
- [ ] Eat a real meal on your wedding day — assign someone to bring you food during prep
- [ ] Drink water — dehydration is the silent saboteur of weddings
- [ ] Have a 10-minute quiet moment with your partner before the ceremony if possible
- [ ] Write a note to your partner the night before — you'll want to have done this

THE EMERGENCY CONTACT SHEET

Print this and give to: your venue coordinator, MOH, best man, and photographer.

> **Wedding Day Emergency Contact Sheet** Venue: [Name | Address | Coordinator cell] Photographer: [Name | Cell] Caterer: [Name | Cell] DJ/Band: [Name | Cell] Florist: [Name | Cell] Officiant: [Name | Cell] Transportation: [Name | Cell | Confirmation #] Couple's Emergency Contact: [Name | Relationship | Cell]

> **If you do nothing else today:** Print and distribute the emergency contact sheet. Even if nothing goes wrong, knowing it exists will help every person on your team breathe easier.

Page 11: Day-of Emergency Kit

37 Items. Every Single One Has Saved a Wedding.

[Image: a flat-lay of an emergency kit — small bag, safety pins, stain remover, band-aids, mints, phone charger]

Build this kit. Put it in a small bag. Give it to your MOH or day-of coordinator. Thank yourself later.

THE 37-ITEM WEDDING EMERGENCY KIT

Clothing & Appearance

- [ ] Safety pins (at least 12 — various sizes)
- [ ] Fashion tape (double-sided)
- [ ] Needle and thread (white, black, and matching dress color)
- [ ] Stain remover pen (Tide To Go)
- [ ] Hem tape (iron-on and peel-and-stick)
- [ ] Extra pair of nude undergarments
- [ ] Bobby pins (50+) and hair ties
- [ ] Clear nail polish (for runs in stockings)
- [ ] Compact mirror

Health & Comfort

- [ ] Ibuprofen and Tylenol
- [ ] Antacids (Tums or equivalent)
- [ ] Blister bandages (specifically — heel blisters are universal)
- [ ] Regular bandages (assorted)
- [ ] Allergy medication
- [ ] Feminine hygiene products
- [ ] Eye drops (for the couple and for tearful family)
- [ ] Breath mints (not gum — gum shows in photos)

- [ ] Deodorant
- [ ] Dental floss + floss picks
- [ ] Hand sanitizer

Technology & Admin

- [ ] Phone charger + portable battery pack (fully charged)
- [ ] Printed copy of vendor contact sheet (do not rely on your phone)
- [ ] Printed day-of timeline (one for each coordinator/vendor lead)
- [ ] Printed seating chart (backup copy)
- [ ] Envelopes with vendor tips pre-counted and labeled
- [ ] Pen and small notepad
- [ ] USB drive with ceremony music (backup for DJ/officiant)

Venue & Environment

- [ ] Mini umbrella (compact, fits in the bag)
- [ ] Small sewing scissors
- [ ] Superglue (one small tube — for anything from shoes to décor)
- [ ] Clear tape
- [ ] Extra candle lighter or long matches (for décor/unity candles)
- [ ] Corkscrew (you'd be surprised)

For the Couple

- [ ] A snack that won't stain (crackers, nuts, protein bar)
- [ ] Water bottle
- [ ] Small gift or note from your partner (put it in the kit the night before)
- [ ] A card with your vows written out (even if you've memorized them)

> **If you do nothing else today:** Order or assemble the physical items in this kit at least 2 weeks before the wedding. Do not trust Amazon Prime the week of.

Page 12: What Comes Next

You Survived the Checklist. Now Get the Full Playbook.

[Image: the cover of the Wedding Planning & Execution Survival Guide 2026 — clean, warm, professional]

This free checklist covers the skeleton. The full **Wedding Planning & Execution Survival Guide 2026** covers everything in between.

What the full 100-page guide includes:

- Section 1: The Wedding Industrial Complex — how to not get taken advantage of
- Section 2: The Complete Budget Tracker (with every line item and formula)
- Section 3: Vendor Negotiation Scripts and Contract Red Flags
- Section 4: The Guest Experience Blueprint (from invitation to send-off)
- Section 5: The Ceremony Design Workbook
- Section 6: The Reception Playbook — timeline, music, flow, toasts
- Section 7: When Things Go Wrong — a real-world problem/solution index
- **BONUS 1:** Google Sheets Wedding Budget Tracker (fully formula-driven)
- **BONUS 2:** Notion Wedding Dashboard (day-by-day planning system)
- **BONUS 3:** 5 Video Scripts for Planning Your Dream Wedding
- **BONUS 4:** 25 Printable Checklists + Day-of Emergency Kit PDF

All of this for $57.

No subscription. No upsells. One download. Keep it forever.

> **Available at weddingforge.com**

A FINAL NOTE

Weddings are not supposed to be this stressful. The industry profits from your overwhelm — from the idea that if you don't book the right vendor, buy the right dress, pick the right flowers, you will somehow fail at the most important day of your life.

You will not.

The best weddings I've ever witnessed were the ones where the couple showed up present, prepared, and genuinely happy to be in the room. Not the ones with the biggest budgets or the most Instagram-worthy florals.

This guide — free and paid — exists to give you the clarity to show up that way.

You've got this. Now go plan your wedding.

— WeddingForge

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--- END OF PHASE 1 ---

NEXT?